

The 6:15

WEDNESDAY · SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

NO. 22

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Wed 9/30, 8:30a	August PCE price index (BEA) — last inflation read before Oct. 27-28 FOMC; not yet released as of this writing.
Wed 9/30, aft. close	Micron FQ4 2026 earnings (call 4:30p ET); consensus ~\$31.40 EPS/\$50.9B rev, within guidance [NEW] .
Thu 10/1, aft. close	Nike FQ1 2027 earnings; consensus \$0.44 EPS/\$11.33B rev (23 analysts, Alphastreet) — carried from Monday, not reverified this run.
Fri 10/2, 8:00p	Northwestern hosts Penn State (3-1), Ryan Field — venue debut.
Mon 10/5	Knicks preseason opens at Philadelphia; Constellation Brands (STZ) FQ2 earnings, consensus \$3.63 EPS/\$2.5B rev [NEW] .

Standing: FOMC next meets Oct. 27-28; hike odds ~64% (Kalshi/Polymarket avg, Sept. 26) vs. 65%-72% cited Monday (CME-based) — different methodology, both still point to majority-hike pricing ahead of today's PCE. Fed's Waller speaks on the economic outlook and Bowman at a bank-regulation roundtable this week; exact same-day timing not fully confirmed this run **(flag)**. October Treasury supply: 7Y \$44B/10Y \$39B recommended (TBAC, Aug. 5) — exact auction dates not yet announced **[NEW]**. Dec. 11 CR funding deadline stands; OPEC+ October JMMC date still unconfirmed [continuity]. No actual reading located this run for Tuesday's Case-Shiller/Consumer Confidence/JOLTS batch — last confirmed prints remain August Confidence (89.4) and July JOLTS openings (7.27M).

METRICS · ET UNLESS NOTED

Brent · WTI	\$97.23 (+1.12%) · \$90.31 (+1.04%), spread ~\$6.92 (intraday feed, ~6:10a, not a settle)
2Y · 10Y · 30Y	4.94% (Mon close, not reconfirmed) · 5.23%-5.26% · 5.59% (Tue close, highest since 2002)
DXY	101.20 (-0.17%, 6:10a) vs. 101.37 Tue close
S&P fut. · Nasdaq 100 fut.	7,737.00 (+0.06%) vs. Tue cash close 7,670.84 (-0.17%) · 30,599.25 (-0.05%)

VIX	16.01 (-0.19%, 6:05a) — up from Mon's confirmed 14.87 close (flag)
Gold	\$4,219.40 (+0.95%, Dec fut., 6:09a) — rebound off Monday's 7-week low
Asia · Europe	Nikkei 66,753.72 (+1.94%, Wed close) · Hang Seng 24,613.27 (+0.37%, close) (date stamp unconfirmed) ; FTSE 10,660.68 (+0.23%, 11:05a BST, still trading) · DAX 25,344.24 (-0.22%, 12:05p CEST)
Retail gas	\$4.4343/gal AAA natl. avg, confirmed 9/30 — down from \$4.4768 (9/28)

Crude and equity-futures levels are real-time feeds ahead of NY settle/open (TradingEconomics, Yahoo Finance), not closing prints; rows above carry their own date/time stamp rather than a single as-of line.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Transits	1 on Sept. 20 vs. 85.5/day 2025 baseline (IMF PortWatch) — still most recent published day (no fresher figure located)
Vessels holding	233 AIS-visible, 02:49 UTC Sept. 28 (Windward/straits.live) (not reconfirmed today)
War-risk premia	~7.5%-10% of hull value fleet-wide (Howden Re/Marsh/S&P Global range) — unchanged

Methodology: transit counts (PortWatch, lagged), stranded-vessel counts (AIS, daily-volatile) and war-risk premia (insurance-market reporting, periodic) measure different things over different windows and vendors; never averaged or differenced here.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Lost ALWC Gm 1 to Red Sox, 3-1, Yankee Stadium; series 0-1
Knicks	Training camp continues; no personnel moves
Northwestern	No reported moves in the last 24 hours

LEAD

IRAN REJECTS, MARKETS DON'T

Trump calls Iran's Hormuz plan unacceptable on camera; crude sells off anyway

Trump delivered his rejection of Iran's seven-day Hormuz-reopening plan straight to cameras Monday: "I'd like to make a deal, too. But that deal would not be acceptable." [fact] That's a harder public line than Sunday's account from Waltz, and it landed a day before Araghchi's Tuesday window for an "official" written response through Qatari mediators — a window that passed without one. As of 7:20p ET Tuesday, Araghchi was still describing himself as "waiting for an official response from America through the intermediary," and Iran's security chief Rezaei said Trump is "trapped in a quagmire where he can neither negotiate nor fight." [fact] Both governments are now negotiating in public while the actual channel — Doha — stays closed to outside view; nothing here confirms whether Trump's on-camera line is policy or leverage ahead of a written answer.

Crude did not treat it as escalation. Brent traded at \$97.23 (+1.12% intraday, TradingEconomics, ~6:10a ET) and WTI at \$90.31 (+1.04%) this morning — both roughly 8%-9% below the \$105-108 Brent/\$93-94 WTI range this brief carried Tuesday, with no change in the physical Hormuz counters (transits still effectively zero, the vessel-holding count last confirmed at 233 Monday, war-risk premia unchanged in the 7.5%-10% hull-value band). [fact] That's the mechanism worth sitting with: a public rejection that reads harder than anything Waltz said last week, delivered into a market that had already priced a chunk of headline risk into a Strait that remains shut, and the price is unwinding rather than extending. Two reads, both live: either the desk is treating Trump's line as negotiating posture rather than a policy shift — consistent with Monday's Axios/CNN report that he'd privately accept sanctions relief after "concrete progress" — or the move has little to do with Iran at all,

and is a standalone reversal after a crisis premium that had run ahead of the actual disruption. [read] The counters didn't move, so this is a repricing of risk, not new information about the Strait itself.

What didn't move with it: the long end of the curve. Thirty-year Treasuries closed Tuesday at 5.59% — a fresh high since 2002 — and the 10-year held in the 5.23%-5.26% band that's been a 2007-level floor since mid-September. [fact] If cheaper energy were the dominant story for inflation expectations, duration would likely be rallying alongside it; it isn't, which points to term-premium and fiscal-supply pressure carrying more weight in this move than the energy channel does — October's Treasury calendar alone calls for a recommended \$44B in 7-year and \$39B in 10-year supply (TBAC, Aug. 5), a load the market has to absorb regardless of where crude settles. [fact] Equities read the oil drop as the good kind of surprise — S&P futures +0.06%, gold rebounding off Monday's seven-week low — while the VIX ticked up to 16.01 from Monday's confirmed 14.87 close, a small but real two-session rise that sits oddly next to a green futures tape. [read]

All of this lands hours before the August PCE print at 8:30a ET — the last inflation read before the Oct. 27-28 FOMC, where prediction markets (Kalshi/Polymarket average, Sept. 26) still price roughly a 64% chance of a second 2026 hike. [fact] Bank consensus going in: core PCE +0.2% m/m, ~3.0% y/y, a touch softer than July's 0.27% pace. [fact, forecast] A hot print against falling energy costs would be the most hawkish combination on the table this morning — it would mean the disinflation the oil market is pricing isn't showing up in the data yet, and duration's refusal to rally would look prescient rather than stale.

POLITICS

China's rare-earth export-control suspension — the 12-month pause covering samarium, gadolinium, terbium, dysprosium, lutetium, scandium and yttrium — is due to expire Nov. 10, five weeks before the broader Busan trade truce's Jan. 10 renewal date. [NEW, fact] Six months into the pause, Beijing has shown "little sign" of easing the underlying licensing regime, per Benchmark Minerals reporting, and added MP Materials and USA Rare Earth to its entity list in June, barring any transfer of Chinese-origin dual-use items to either firm. [fact] The mismatched deadlines put a rare-earth-specific flashpoint back on the calendar five weeks before the broader tariff truce needs renewing — a sequencing problem distinct from, but structurally similar to, the one stalling Hormuz talks (Lead).

ECONOMICS

August PCE (BEA, 8:30a ET) had not printed as of this writing; bank consensus points to core +0.2% m/m, ~3.0% y/y — cooler than July's 0.27% pace but still north of target. [forecast, not yet actual] The Sept. 18 hike that took the funds rate to 3.75%-4.00% passed unanimously, and the Fed's own dot plot showed 16 of 18 FOMC participants penciling in one more 2026 hike; Chair Warsh's post-meeting language leaned on the same hawkish register as his August Jackson Hole remarks. [fact] That's the backdrop today's PCE lands against: a committee that has already told markets, in writing, it expects to move again absent a clear disinflation signal. Tuesday's scheduled batch — July Case-Shiller, September Consumer Confidence, August JOLTS — released on time, but no actual reading for any of the three was located against a primary BLS/Conference Board source this run; the last confirmed prints on

file remain August Confidence (89.4) and July JOLTS openings (7.27M). [flag]

BUSINESS

Credit markets are not pricing the Treasury market's stress: investment-grade corporate spreads sit near 80bp over Treasuries (BBB ~100bp, AA ~50bp) — levels last this tight since 1998 — while high-yield spreads hold near 285bp, with BB-rated credit near its tightest of the cycle and CCC the one segment showing genuine widening. [fact] That combination — record-tight IG spreads against a 30-year Treasury yield at a 24-year high (Lead) — says the multi-decade move in long rates is a Treasury-supply and term-premium story, not a corporate-credit-risk one; investors are still willing to hold corporate paper at a historically thin premium to a benchmark they're demanding more yield from. [read] Thursday's Nike print and today's Micron numbers (Technology) are the first real test of whether that credit-market calm matches what shows up in actual corporate results.

TECHNOLOGY

Micron reports FQ4 2026 after Wednesday's close, call at 4:30p ET; consensus lands near \$31.40 EPS on \$50.9B revenue, inside the company's own \$30-\$32/\$49B-\$51B guidance and roughly 350% higher on EPS than a year ago — a scale of growth that reflects AI-driven memory demand rather than a one-off beat. [fact, forecast] That makes it this week's clearest read on whether the AI capex cycle behind Nvidia's OpenAgent platform (issue No. 21) is still converting into hard demand for the chips underneath it, set against Thursday's Nike print testing the opposite, tariff-exposed end of the

consumer/industrial spectrum. No frontier-model release or other launch news confirmed overnight. [continuity]

GEOPOLITICS

Zelenskyy said Russia launched nearly 500 attack drones and more than 40 missiles, including Kinzhal hypersonics, in a barrage spanning over 12 hours that hit Kyiv, Zaporizhzhia, Khmelnytskyi, Sumy and Odesa oblasts, striking a bread factory and a tire plant among other civilian and industrial sites. [fact] That is a materially larger barrage than the Sumy-focused strikes this brief reported Tuesday (issue No. 21); some outlets date it to the night of Sept. 28, which would overlap with material already filed, so the exact night and a reconciled casualty count are not fully confirmed this run. [flag, developing] Zelenskyy called again for the US, Europe, G7 and G20 to respond and said Ukraine will continue counterstrikes "to force Russia into diplomacy." [fact] No new confirmed Houthi-Saudi strike located past issue No. 21's Sept. 26 cutoff; the Makkah Joint Defense Agreement stands unactivated. [continuity]

IRAN & HORMUZ

Physical counters carried no fresh move overnight (Board): PortWatch's most recent published daily transit figure remains Sept. 20 (1 vessel vs. an 85.5/day 2025 baseline); the 233-vessel AIS holding count is Monday's reading, not reconfirmed today. [flag] War-risk premia held in the 7.5%-10% hull-value band from Howden Re/Marsh/S&P Global reporting, which updates periodically rather than daily — the lag that explains why the Board's physical counters look unchanged even as spot crude moved sharply (Lead). MV Cape Dao remains unclaimed by Iran or the US a week after the Musandam torpedo attack that killed Indian crew member Suraj Yadav; no attribution has been announced. [continuity,

fact] Separately, the blockade's economic toll on Iran itself has deepened: crude and condensate loadings averaged just 220,000-260,000 b/d in August, versus 1.7-2.0 million b/d a year earlier — an over-80% collapse — and National Iranian Oil Co. output could fall to 1.2-1.3 million b/d if the blockade holds, per outside analyst estimates. [fact] Floating storage tied to Iranian crude fell from roughly 90 million barrels in mid-July to about 29 million by mid-September, and 27 sanctioned tankers linked to Iran's trade sit idle in ballast off Sri Lanka, unable to return to port. [fact] That erosion is the pressure both Waltz and Araghchi are negotiating against (Lead) — the longer the Strait stays effectively shut, the more it costs Tehran specifically, which cuts against reading today's stalemate as free optionality for Iran. [read]

SPORTS

Yankees	Lost ALWC Gm 1 to Red Sox, 3-1, Yankee Stadium — Crochet retired 17 straight, Yoshida's 2-run pinch single decided it; series 0-1, Gm 2 date not confirmed this run.
Knicks	Training camp continues; no game, no personnel moves; preseason opens Mon. 10/5 at Philadelphia.
Northwestern	2-1; no game since Sept. 25 loss at Indiana; hosts Penn State (3-1) Fri. 10/2, 8p, Ryan Field (venue debut).

Continuity. Nike's Vietnam/China sourcing mix and the 120bp margin-headwind figure (issue No. 21) carry over unchanged ahead of Thursday's earnings and are not restated above. Not refreshed this run: today's actual Case-Shiller/Consumer Confidence/JOLTS prints (searched, not located); today's PortWatch/AIS Hormuz counters; ALWC Game 2 date/time; exact timing of this week's Fed speakers. Watch for next issue: August PCE actual (8:30a); Micron's post-close print and Thursday's Nike FQ1; ALWC Game 2; any formal written US-Iran response via Doha; reconciliation of last night's Ukraine barrage against issue No. 21's Sumy item.

Unverified figures flagged this issue: Brent/WTI and equity-futures levels are real-time feeds, not settles; VIX's rise to 16.01 and the Hang Seng's 24,613.27 close carry no fully confirmed session-date stamp; Hormuz transit and AIS vessel counts are carried from Sept. 20/28 rather than reconfirmed today; today's PCE, Case-Shiller, Consumer Confidence and JOLTS actuals were not

located this run — consensus or prior-period figures were used instead and labeled as such. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.